FREE BROCHURE

Teaching Public and Private



A guide for parents, teachers, SNAs and carers on teaching public and private in the same way at home and at school.

WHO IT IS FOR

Parents, carers, teachers, SNAs, and staff in residential and respite settings who support autistic children and young people.

NCCA STAGE

All stages · For adults



Easy read

Public and private is a rule about places. We teach it the same way at home and at school. We teach it calmly, with no shame.

How to use this resource

- Read pages 2 and 3 first. They explain the idea and the steps for teaching it.
- Agree your shared words with the other adults in your child's life, then write them on the card on page 6.
- Use the scripts on page 4 when something happens. Practise them before you need them.
- Share the guide with school, respite or residential staff so everyone says the same thing.

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Why public and private matters

Many autistic children learn rules best when they are literal, visual and the same every time. 'Public and private' is a rule about places, bodies and information. It helps children and young people to feel comfortable, stay safe, and avoid embarrassment or harm.

It is not about shame. Bodies are fine and normal. The teaching is about **where** and **who**, not about whether something is wrong.



Public: lots of people can be there.



Private: I can be on my own there.



Private things happen in private places.



I can ask a trusted adult if I am not sure.

Shared language

Pick a small set of short, literal phrases. Use the same words at home, in school, on the school bus, and in any respite or residential setting. Avoid hints like 'not now' or 'that's not nice', which can be unclear.

Instead of...	Say...
'Stop that, it's rude.'	'That is private. Bedroom or bathroom.'
'Not here!'	'That is for your bedroom. Let's go there.'
'Be careful what you tell people.'	'Your address is private. We do not tell strangers.'
'Don't be silly.'	'Clothes stay on in the classroom.'

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Teaching steps

1. **Teach the words first.** Use the correct names for body parts: penis, testicles, scrotum, vulva, vagina, clitoris, anus, breasts, nipples. Say them calmly and factually.
2. **Teach public and private places.** Use photos of your own home and school. Sort them with a poster or sorting cards. Our poster 'Public and Private Places' is a good start.
3. **Teach private body parts.** 'The parts under your underwear are private.' Use a body outline or a doll. Say that these parts stay covered in public.
4. **Teach private actions and where they happen.** Using the toilet, changing clothes, and touching your own body all happen in a private place, such as the bathroom or bedroom with the door closed.
5. **Teach private information.** Name, school, address, passwords and photos are not for strangers or the internet. Teach who can know what.
6. **Practise with scripts and role-play.** Rehearse what to say and do. Praise effort.
7. **Respond calmly when it goes wrong.** Name the place, redirect, and move on. No shouting, no shame.
8. **Check it works in every setting.** Ask school, respite and family: are we all saying the same thing?

Notes for adults: what helps

- Use visuals: photos of your own rooms, a simple traffic-light card, a poster on the bedroom door.
- Teach at a calm time, when your child is regulated. Teach before a problem, not only after one.
- Praise the right behaviour: 'Well done, you went to your bedroom.'
- Some children have sensory reasons for taking off clothes (for example, heat or itchy fabric). Look for the cause, adjust the clothing, and still teach where clothes come off.
- Touching their own body is normal. Teach the place, not that it is wrong. If it happens a lot or seems linked to pain or distress, talk to your GP.
- No diagnosis is needed to use any of these supports.

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What to say: scripts for common situations

Say these quietly and calmly. Use a neutral voice. Offer a clear next step. Afterwards, praise the child for going to the right place.

A child touches their private parts in class

'That is private. Bedroom or bathroom. Let's go to the bathroom.'

A child takes their clothes off in a public place

'Clothes stay on here. This is a public place. Let's put your clothes back on.'

A child talks about private things to a stranger

'That is private. We tell family and trusted adults. Let's tell Mum together.'

A young person shares private information online

'Your photos and address are private. Let's look at your settings together.'

A child opens a closed door on someone

'That door is closed. We knock and wait. Let's knock together.'

A child asks why something is private

'Some things are for private places. It is a rule that keeps everyone comfortable and safe.'

Online

The internet is public. A photo or message online can be copied and shared. Sharing, or threatening to share, an intimate image of someone without their consent is a crime in Ireland (Coco's Law, 2020). A sexual image of anyone under 18 is treated as child sexual abuse material under Irish law, even if it is an image of themselves. If a young person has sent or been sent an image, do not blame them and do not forward it. Stay calm, tell a trusted adult, and report at hotline.ie. For advice see webwise.ie.

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Common questions

Question	Answer
Is it OK for my child to touch their own body?	Yes, it is normal. Teach that it is private and happens in a private place. Respond calmly, without shame.
My child takes their clothes off when they are upset or hot. What do I do?	Look for the cause: sensory discomfort, temperature, or needing a break. Offer alternatives, then teach where clothes can come off.
Won't this make my child ashamed?	Not if you teach it calmly. Keep your voice neutral. Say what to do, not what is wrong.
How do I explain it without upsetting my child?	Use short, literal sentences, pictures and the same words each time. Stay calm.
My child does not follow rules about private parts in public. What next?	Check that the rule is clear and visual. Practise often. Look at whether there is a reason, such as pain, boredom or sensory need.
Is it OK for adults to help with intimate care?	Some children need help. Agree who does it, where and how. Tell the child what is happening in advance. Two staff may be needed in school; follow the school's intimate care policy.

Residential and respite settings

- Ask staff to use the same shared words you use at home. Share this guide and your child's poster.
- Bedroom doors: agree knocking and waiting. A bedroom door can be closed, and staff knock first.
- Intimate care: agree who helps, how it is explained, and that it happens in a private place. Keep a written plan.
- Make sure there is a private place to dress and wash, and a private place for personal time.
- Keep the child's voice at the centre. Ask them how they feel and what they prefer.

Shared bedrooms

- Agree private times: for example, one child dresses in the bathroom, or the other leaves the room.
- Use a screen, curtain or a 'private time' sign when someone is dressing.
- Give each child their own space for belongings, even a drawer or box.
- Teach siblings to knock and wait, even when the door is open.

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Our shared words card

Fill this in with the other adults in your child's life. Copy it and share it.

Shared language

Our word for 'public' is: _____

Our word for 'private' is: _____

What we say when something private happens in public:

_____

Where my child goes for private time: _____

Who knows these words (home, school, respite): _____

Our names for body parts

Names we use at home: _____

Names the school uses: _____

If you are worried

If a child's behaviour changes suddenly, or they say something that worries you, stay calm and listen. Talk to your GP, the school's Designated Liaison Person (DLP) or Tusla. See Children First (2017). You are not overreacting. Asking for advice is the right thing to do.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand units *Taking care of my body* and *Safety and protection*; Stay Safe programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality** and Strand 1 **Understanding Myself and Others**.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: use explicit, visual and consistent teaching, and involve parents so home and school match.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Webwise

Online safety advice for parents, teachers and young people at webwise.ie.

Hotline.ie

Report intimate images shared without consent, and child sexual abuse material, at hotline.ie. They can help get images removed.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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